

BOARD GAME RULEBOOK

Your Move: How Game Design Brings History to Life | Shady Side Academy

Game Title: Cruellest Years

Designed by: Larry, Oliver, Leon, Jeff

Historical Event: WWII

HOW TO USE THIS TEMPLATE

This template follows the structure of a real published board game rulebook. Work through each section in order. Replace all instructions, guiding questions, and placeholder text with your own content. Write in complete sentences. Delete any section that does not apply to your game and briefly note why. Your finished rulebook should be clear enough that someone who has never seen your game can pick it up and play without asking you a single question.

Your final rulebook should go beyond plain text. Real rulebooks use images, icons, diagrams, color, and layout to make rules easier to understand. Once your rules are written and playtested, spend time designing the look — add illustrations, maps, card mockups, or any visuals that help a player understand your game faster. A well-designed rulebook is part of the game.

→ Guiding questions in this style are design prompts to help you think. Delete them before submitting.

🚩 **Questions in this style are history checks. They exist to make sure your game is actually rooted in the history — not just using it as decoration. If you cannot answer these, your design needs more work. Delete them before submitting.**

RESEARCHING GAME MECHANICS

A mechanic is the system that drives player decisions — worker placement, hand management, area control, negotiation, deck building, and many more. Before you write your rulebook, explore what mechanics other designers have used and find ones that fit your historical event. The mechanic should feel like a natural expression of the history, not something bolted on.

BoardGameGeek — Browse All Mechanics: <https://boardgamegeek.com/browse/boardgamemechanic>

PLAYER REFERENCE CARD

Most published board games include a player reference card — a single card or half-sheet that summarizes the key information each player needs during the game. It is not a replacement for the rulebook; it is a quick reminder so players do not need to flip through pages mid-game.

A good reference card typically includes: turn structure at a glance, action costs or point values, a summary of each role's special ability, and the win condition. Design and include a player reference card as part of your final submission.

1. Contents

List every physical component in your game with exact quantities. A player opening your box for the first time should be able to verify that everything is there.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

- What type of component is it and what is it used for?
- If players have their own pieces, are they listed separately for each player?

→ Are any components shared by all players vs. owned by one player?

📌 **Do your components reflect the historical world — do the names, images, or design of your pieces connect to real people, places, factions, or objects from the event?**

[List all components here]

2. Overview

Introduce your game in 3–5 sentences. Set the historical scene, establish the stakes, and give the reader a sense of what playing feels like. This is the first thing a new player reads — make it compelling.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

→ Who are the players and what are they trying to do?

→ What emotion or tension should a player feel from the very first turn?

📌 **Does your overview accurately represent the historical event — the real people, the real stakes, the real conflict? If someone who knew the history read this, would they recognize it?**

📌 **What was the central tension or decision that real historical actors faced? Is that tension present in your game?**

[Write your overview here]

3. Objective

State the win condition clearly and precisely. A player should be able to read this once and immediately understand what they are working toward.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

→ Is there one win condition for all players, or do different players have different objectives?

→ Can the game end in a draw? If so, how is that handled?

📌 **Does your win condition reflect what real historical actors were actually fighting for — their real goals, not a simplified version? Would winning your game feel like winning historically mattered?**

📌 **Could a player win your game while completely ignoring the historical theme? If yes, your objective and your history are not connected yet.**

Win Condition (Plus together for playing multiple regions)

Domination Victory

Take over a certain number of cities.

World

21/41 for solo victory, 28/41 for team victory.

European:

12/21 for solo victory, 15/21 for team victory.

Asia:

6/11 for solo victory, 8/11 for team victory.

4. Number of Players & Roles

State the player count and describe each role. For each role, explain what it wants, what it can uniquely do, and what its limitations are.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

Number of players:

Players work in teams? (Y / N):

- Are any roles asymmetric — do they have different rules, abilities, or goals from each other?
- Is any role significantly more powerful than others, and if so, how is that balanced?
- 🚩 **Does each role correspond to a real historical faction, group, or perspective from the event — not just a generic role with a historical name attached?**
- 🚩 **Do the different roles reflect the fact that different groups had different goals, different resources, and different constraints in the real historical event?**
- 🚩 **Are there groups from the real historical event who are affected by the outcome but have no playable role in your game? Name them.**
- 🚩 **How did you decide whose perspective to include and whose to leave out? Is that a responsible design choice?**

2-6 players

5. Setup

Walk through setup in numbered steps. A player should be able to follow these instructions and be ready for the first turn without asking any questions.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

- Where does each player start on the board or in the game space?
- How are cards, tokens, or other components distributed at the start?
- How is the first player determined?
- 🚩 **Does the starting setup reflect the historical reality at the beginning of the event — who had power, who had resources, who was vulnerable? If every player starts equally, is that a conscious design choice or did you just not think about it yet?**

[Write your numbered setup steps here]

6. Gameplay

Describe the structure of a full round. Break it into numbered phases and explain precisely what happens in each one. If the order of operations matters, say so explicitly. Include how any event cards or random elements are triggered within the turn structure.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

- What are the phases of a round, in order?
- What decisions does a player make on their turn, and what information do they have — and not have — when making them?
- What happens between turns — do other players react, draw cards, or take any actions?
- If your game includes event cards or random elements, when are they triggered and who do they affect? What do they represent?
- See the BoardGameGeek mechanics list above if you need language to describe what your core mechanic does.
- 🚩 **Does your core mechanic reflect something true about how the historical event actually worked — how decisions were made, how power shifted, how conflict played out?**
- 🚩 **If you removed all the historical names and replaced them with generic ones, would your game still feel like it was about this specific event? If yes, your mechanics and history are not integrated enough.**
- 🚩 **What real historical constraint — a resource shortage, a time pressure, a diplomatic limitation — inspired a rule in your game?**

1. Gain gold (national treasury points), population and weapon from your cities and factories

- Cities produce +5 gold and +1 population per turn.
- Factories produce +1 weapon unit per turn.

2. Use the leader's / territorial abilities.

- Passive abilities are always working
- Active abilities have to be triggered;
some abilities have costs that you have to consume something to trigger;
some other abilities have Cooldown written as CD which means you can't use the ability for a certain number of turns.

3. Choose what and where to train military units.

- Untrained units can be formed with discarding populations and weapon units indicated in the military units table.
- It takes one turn for the military units to be trained,
untrained military units can't move until the next turn.

4. You can choose to move and attack units

- HP of units are HP coin under the unit, when the unit got attacked, there will be amount of HP coins removed under the military unit equivalent to the attacking unit's attack
- Units can attack after move,
but can't move after attack unless specially indicated.
- Units can't stand in the same tile
- Units without HP coins will be removed from the map
- Units can attack outside of their range but in order to hit the player must succeed on a coin flip for an additional tile.

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7. Special Abilities or Cards

List every special ability, power, or card effect in your game. For each one, name it, describe exactly what it does, and state when and how it can be used.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

- Is this ability tied to a specific role, card, or game condition?
- Can it only be used once per game, once per round, or is it unlimited?
- What makes this ability balanced — what does it cost, require, or risk?

■ **Does each special ability reflect something historically accurate about the figure or faction it represents — a real military advantage, a real political power, a real cultural practice?**

■ **If a player used a special ability in a way that the real historical actor never could or would, does that break the historical integrity of your game? How did you guard against that?**

[List and describe each special ability or card here]

8. Game End

Describe in full detail how the game ends and how a winner is determined. This section must leave no ambiguity — disputes at the end of a game almost always trace back to a vague game end rule.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

- What triggers the end of the game?
- If someone meets the win condition mid-round, does the round finish before the game ends?
- Is there a tiebreaker? What is it?

■ **Does your ending connect to a real historical outcome? Does winning feel like it meant something historically — or does it feel arbitrary?**

■ **In the real historical event, was there a clear winner and loser, or was the outcome more complicated? How does your game handle that complexity?**

[Describe your game end conditions here]

9. Glossary (Optional)

Define every term in your game that is specific to your design or that players might misunderstand. List definitions alphabetically.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

- Are there mechanical terms — like "action points," "control," or "influence" — that need a precise definition specific to your game?

→ Is there any word used in your rulebook that means something different in your game than in everyday language?

📌 **Are there historical terms — titles, place names, political concepts — that players might not know? Define them here so the history is accessible, not a barrier.**

[List your glossary terms and definitions alphabetically, or delete this section entirely]

10. FAQ & Edge Cases

Come back to this section after every playtest session. As you play, write down every question your playtesters ask out loud, every moment someone says "wait, can I do that?", and every situation your rules did not clearly cover. Then answer each one here. This section turns your playtest confusion into finished rules. A complete FAQ is one of the clearest signs that a designer has actually tested their game with real players and taken the feedback seriously.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

- What is the most confusing rule in your game? Address it directly.
- What happens if two rules seem to contradict each other?
- What happens if a player runs out of a resource or component mid-game?
- What situations came up during playtesting that the main rules did not cover?

📌 **Did any edge cases arise from the historical theme specifically — situations that could happen in the history but felt unclear in your game rules? Address them here.**

[Write your FAQ and edge case rulings here]

11. Strategy Notes (Optional)

This section is optional. If you include it, write 3–5 tips that help a new player get started. Focus on helping players understand the spirit of the game — not on giving away dominant winning strategies.

♦ **Delete all guiding questions and instructions before submitting your final rulebook.**

- What is the most common mistake new players make?
- What does a strong opening look like?

📌 **Is there something about the real historical event that gives a player who understands the history a meaningful strategic advantage? That is a sign your history and your mechanics are genuinely connected.**

[Write your strategy notes here, or delete this section entirely]

12. Credits

List everyone who contributed. Include designers, playtesters, and the historical sources that shaped your research.

Designed by: Leon, Jeff, Oliver, Larry

Playtested by:

Historical sources:

Special thanks:

Mr. Solomon, Ms. Wang, Monsieur Roland, Mr. Tyler Crumrine

Course: Your Move
